

Fig. 9.1: Part of the historic dam that has survived (in the foreground) at Junagadh

The way in which the Girnar edicts were inscribed on a single rock ensured that, at least theoretically, it would have been possible for an official placed on a specially created platform to be at eye level with the edicts and read them out to listeners below. The relatively compact manner of the layout made it possible. This was, as we saw, impossible at Erragudi, where the edicts were engraved across multiple boulders at different heights. A more important difference was that the Girnar rock stood—and was probably chosen for this reason—in the vicinity of an artificial lake, not far from the water's edge. Known as Sudarshana lake, this waterbody was created as a consequence of the construction of a dam during the time and on the instructions of Chandragupta Maurya. There is an archaeological configuration of structures and remnants in Junagadh which makes it possible to see Ashoka as part of a dynastic continuum to which he was adding.